

which caused the undermining of the structures and the sliding of the retaining walls built on the slopes.¹⁵

This magnificent courtyard, located at a spot with a spectacular view, suggests the use of Alexandrium also as a palace in the days of Herod.¹⁶ In any event, this fortress was considered suitable for the accommodation of Marcus Agrippa when he visited Herod's kingdom in 15 B.C.E.¹⁷

Alexandrium's sophisticated water supply system, based on the collection of runoff from winter rains in cisterns¹⁸, was mainly (if not entirely) built during the Hasmonaean period.¹⁹ Worthy of mention is the moat to the west of the fortress, which was probably hewn during the Hasmonaean period.²⁰

Doq (Docus or Dagon²¹): This palatial fortress is located to the west of, and some 300 m above, the present-day town of Jericho. The mountain is prominently visible from afar and even nowadays has the appearance of a fortress owing to the walls which were built around its summit on the eve of World War I. The name Docus has been preserved in that of the 'Ein Duyuk spring – one of the three Na'aran springs located at the foot of the mountain on its northern side.

Doq is mentioned both in I Maccabees and in Josephus' *Antiquitates Judaicae*²² in connection with a dramatic event which took place here in 134 B.C.E. – the murder of Simon (one of the five sons of Mattathias and the father of John Hyrcanus I) and two of his sons during a banquet held by Ptolemy, son of Abubos, his son-in-law and *strategos* of the Jericho region.²³ John Hyrcanus, Simons's surviving son, was later about to conquer Doq but was obliged to withdraw following Ptolemy's threat to kill his mother by throwing her from the walls of the fortress.²⁴ While various sources mention the existence of Doq, probably the earliest of all the desert fortresses, during the Hasmonaean period, none of them make reference to it in the context of the Herodian period. Nevertheless, it can reasonably be assumed that Herod continued to use it (and evidently also to extend it), on account of its strategic location and the beauty

¹⁵ A situation similar to that encountered at Cypros.

¹⁶ The fact that some of the column drums bore the remains of Doric stucco fluting, applied in a manner common at some Hasmonaean sites (e.g., in Jericho), below the Herodian frescoes might be indirect evidence that even in the days of the Hasmonaean, Alexandrium served as a palace.

¹⁷ Josephus, *AJ* 16.13.

¹⁸ The fourteen cisterns hewn into the slope, together with the ones located inside the built-up area, had an overall capacity of some 5,000 cubic meters.

¹⁹ D. Amit, "The Aqueduct to the Fortress at Alexandrium," in Amit *et alli* (eds.) 2002, 306–310.

²⁰ See above, note 9.

²¹ Doq is the name referred to in I Mac. 16:11–17; Dagon is the name cited by Josephus (*AJ* 13.230).

²² See above, note 17.

²³ Josephus, *AJ* 13.228.

²⁴ Josephus, *AJ* 13.230–234.

of its surroundings. This assumption is corroborated both by the finds at the site during various surveys and by a small excavation carried out by the present author in 1982.²⁵ Like Alexandrium, Doq benefited from a water system based on channeling of runoff to a series of cisterns hewn at the foot of the fortress.²⁶ Doq too was protected (on the west) by a moat which was probably hewn during the Hasmonaean period.

Nuseib Uweishira: Nuseib Uweishira, a mountain summit resembling a tell to the north of the mouth of Wadi Qelt, is located some 3 km to the south of Doq, overlooking the Jericho Plain. Only remains from the Byzantine period were identified during surveys carried out at the site, but soundings which I conducted in 1976–1977 revealed for the first time remains from the Second Temple period below the ruins of a Byzantine monastery.²⁷ The moat separating the summit from the ridge to its west can thus be dated to the days of the Second Temple, since such means of fortification were no longer in use in the Land of Israel during the Byzantine period. Although only meager finds from the Herodian period were revealed here, including a few walls, floors and a ritual bath, it can be assumed that the initial construction took place during the Hasmonaean period.²⁸ If this is the case, this could have been the site of one of the two fortresses, Threx and Taurus, which, according to Strabo,²⁹ were destroyed by Pompey in 63 B.C.E. In any event, the site was still in use in Herod's day if we are to judge from the material finds uncovered in the excavations.

Cypros: Like Doq and Nuseib Uweishira, Cypros was built on top of a conical-shaped hill towering above the Jericho Plain (ca. 250 m higher than the latter). The site is located directly opposite Nuseib Uweishira (less than one kilometer to its south) on the southern side of the mouth of Wadi Qelt.

While many researchers in the past have tended to identify Cypros as one of the two tells of nearby Tulul Abu el-'Alayiq (the site of the winter palaces), others, including F.M. Abel³⁰ and Z. Meshel, were inclined to identify it as Tell el-'Aqaba, as was finally confirmed by the excavations which I conducted, together with I. Damati, in 1974–1975.³¹ The erroneous identification of Cypros as one of the tells of Tulul Abu el-'Alayiq stemmed from the assumption that

²⁵ The finds from the one-week dig have not yet been published.

²⁶ D. Amit, "The Aqueduct to the Fortress at Dok (Dagon)," in Amit *et alli* (eds.) 2002, 330–335.

²⁷ E. Netzer and R. Birger, "A Byzantine Monastery at Nuseib 'Uweishira, West of Jericho," in G.C. Bottini, L. Di Segni and E. Alliata (eds.), *Christian Archaeology in the Holy Land, New Discoveries* (1990), 191–200.

²⁸ This assumption is based on the form of the tell, which suggests the presence of earlier strata, and the existence of a moat, a common feature at Hasmonaean sites but not at Herodian ones.

²⁹ Strabo, *Geography* 16: 2, 40.

³⁰ F.M. Abel, *Géographie de la Palestine* (1933), 38, 359; O. Ploeger, "Die Makkabäischen Burgen," *ZDPV* 71 (1955), 166–167 and note 14; Shatzman 1991, 227–229.

³¹ A preliminary report on these excavations was published in 1975 (Netzer 1975, 54–6); see

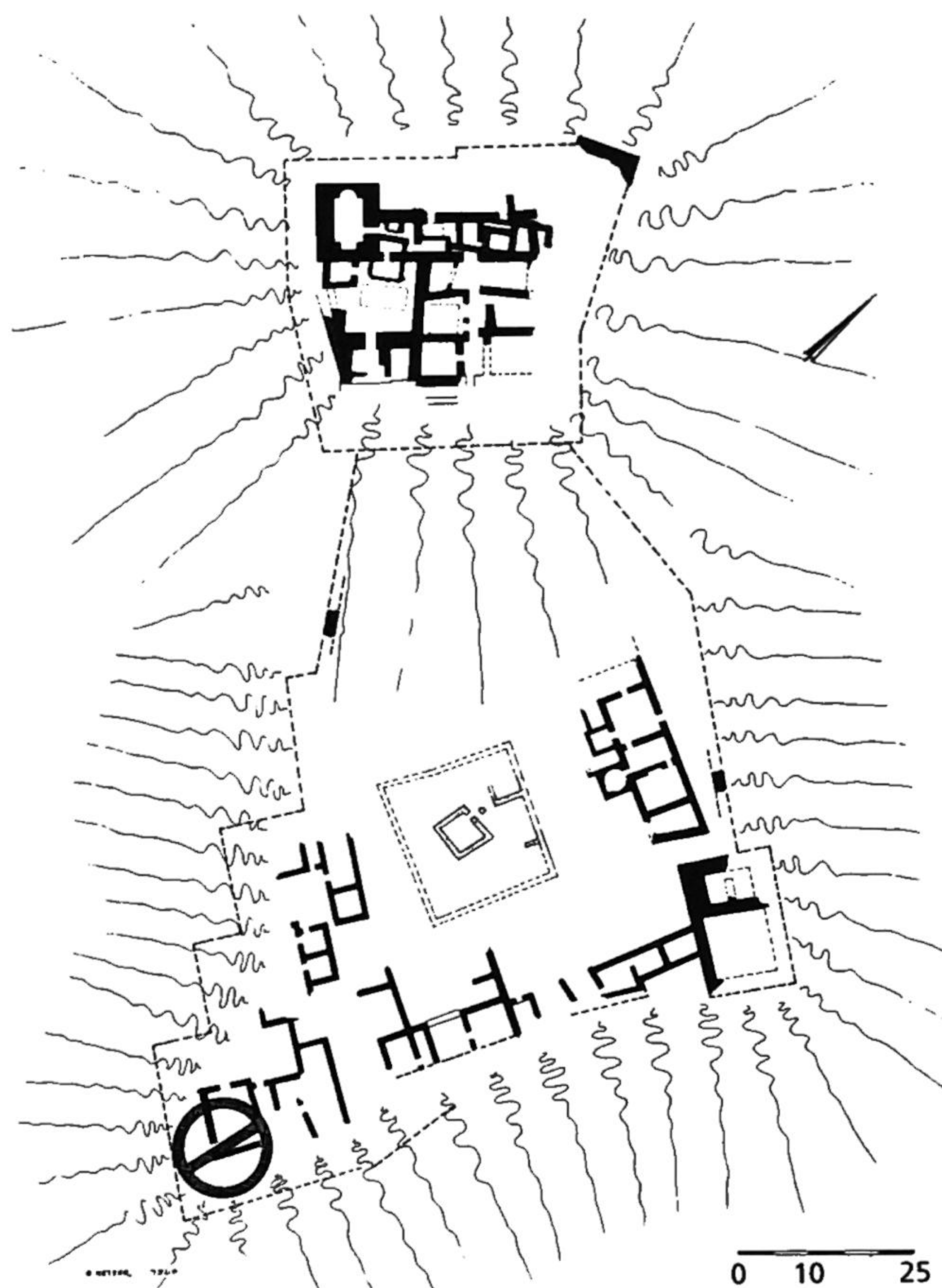


Figure 46: Reconstructed plan of the desert fortress of Cypros (hatched walls: Hasmonaeen; black walls: Herodian; white walls: Byzantine).

the hypocaust and the floor in the *caldarium* have been preserved. The floor consisted of paving stones laid in *opus sectile* patterns. Within a niche on one side of this room a large stone bathtub was found *in situ* (Plate 31). The debris in the *caldarium* included a large fragment of a round marble basin (a *labrum*) which apparently was originally located within a semicircular niche on the other side of the room. Both the *caldarium* and the *tepidarium* were decorated with frescoes. The floor of the *tepidarium* was paved with plain white mosaic. The bathhouse was entered via a fairly large hall (ca. 10 × 8 m) in which were revealed many wooden beams that once supported the ceiling. It appears that this hall served as an entrance hall or a dressing room (*apodyterium*), or was used for gymnastic activities. Adjacent to the hall was a later-added room containing a stepped pool. The addition of a stepped pool to a bathhouse that already contained one, and in particular to this hall, can be compared to the situation at Masada, where a

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